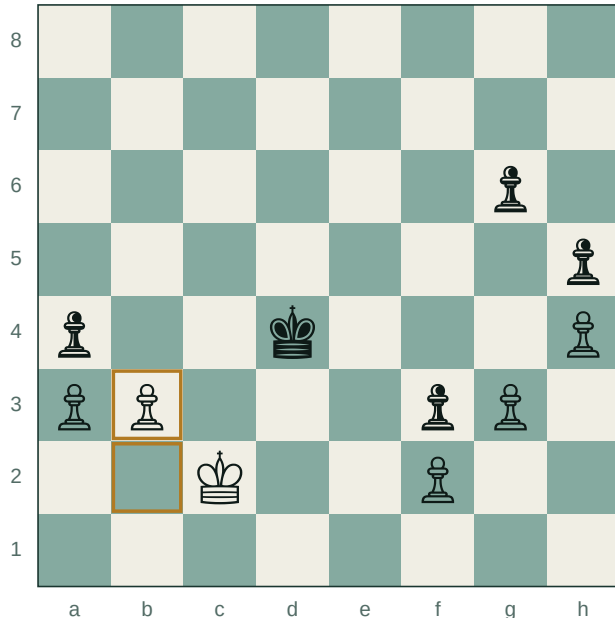


Pawn-ending calculation: Black, move 64

Pawn-ending calculation

Black to move



Previous move: 64.b3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

64...axb3+ 65. Kb2 Kd3 66. a4 Ke2 67. a5 Kxf2

64...axb3+ Check restricts White to 6 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on b3. Recorded reply: **65.Kb2**.

65...Kd3 The king moves from d4 to d3. Recorded reply: **66.a4**.

66...Ke2 The king moves from d3 to e2. Recorded reply: **67.a5**.

67...Kxf2 The king captures the pawn on f2.

At the end, nominal material is White 3 / Black 4 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from -1 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not enter a pawn ending because it looks simple. Rook-pawn exceptions and zugzwang can make a material advantage irrelevant.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

With only kings and pawns, a single tempo can reverse the result. Calculate opposition, capture routes, promotion races, and reserve pawn moves precisely.

HOW TO LOOK

Count actual king moves and pawn pushes, then include whose turn it is and whether promotion gives check.

The defending king is on c2. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.